Evaluate Yourself

6) Arrange the following in the decreasing order of Bond angle

i) CH_4, H_2O, NH_3 ii) C_2H_2, BF_3, CCl_4

10.7 Valence Bond Theory

Heitler and London gave a theoretical treatment to explain the formation of covalent bond in hydrogen molecule on the basis of wave mechanics of electrons. It was further developed by Pauling and Slater. The wave mechanical treatment of VB theory is beyond the scope of this textbook. A simple qualitative treatment of VB theory for the formation of hydrogen molecule is discussed below.

Consider a situation wherein two hydrogen atoms (H_a and H_b) are separated by infinite distance. At this stage there is no interaction between these two atoms and the potential energy of this system is arbitrarily taken as zero. As these two atoms approach each other, in addition to the electrostatic attractive force between the nucleus and its own electron (purple arrows), the following new forces begins to operate.

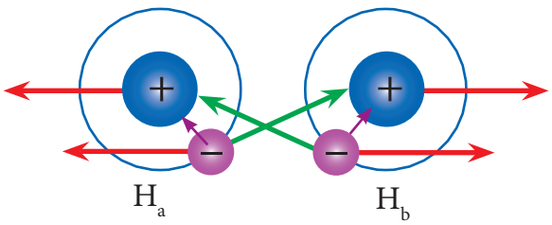

Fig 10. 17 (a) VB theory for the formation of hydrogen molecule

The new attractive forces (green arrows) arise between

(i) nucleus of H_a and valence electron of H_b

(ii) nucleus of H_b and the valence electron of H_a.

The new repulsive forces (red arrows) arise between

(i) the nucleus of H_a and H_b

(ii) valence electrons of H_a and H_b.

The attractive forces tend to bring H_a and H_b together whereas the repulsive forces tends to push them apart. At the initial stage, as the two hydrogen atoms approach each other, the attractive forces are stronger than the repulsive forces and the potential energy decreases. A stage is reached where the net attractive forces are exactly balanced by repulsive forces and the potential energy of the system acquires a minimum energy.

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